



Good governance is non-negotiable, says Sumariwalla on LA 2028 preparation

Good governance is non-negotiable to bring out the best results at the LA 2028 Olympics and other international tournaments, opined Adille Sumariwalla, Vice President, World Athletics, during a panel discussion on 'Learnings from the Paris Games' as part of Sportstar's Focus Bihar Conclave 2025 held in Patna on Friday.

Sumariwalla called for more communication between the stakeholders and a focus on the entire 'ecosystem' behind an athlete rather than holding the federations accountable for all performances.

"I think you need to fix the ecosystem. Just focusing on the athlete and a single coach won't work. It is important to have even the technical officials at an international level," he said.

"The athlete is being given everything they want and they have to go there [Olympics] and perform. The athlete only looks at what he/she wants but he/she doesn't have the experience or the understanding of what is good in the overall ecosystem. Hence, we need to work together as one unit. The overall ecosystem should be strengthened at the national and state level," he said.

Commodore PK Garg, former CEO of the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS), explained how research and interactions between the federation and athletes helps the flagship program. "TOPS involves continuous research on how a select group of athletes can be

developed. There is a synergised, multi-stakeholder approach, which helps TOPS fund each athlete based on their requirement. The Mission Olympic Cell has also been strengthened with the inclusion of sports science, which will improve athlete monitoring and make the scheme more accountable," he said.

Shiva Keshavan, the Deputy Chef-de-Mission for India during Paris 2024 and a former Winter Olympian, provided an internal view from the camp.

"For the first time, both the Chef-de-Mission, Gagan Narang, and the Deputy Chef-de-Mission were Olympians. The impact we could have at the Olympic Village itself, as people who have been through it, knowing what the requirements of the athletes are, we could bridge the gap," Keshavan said.

With the focus shifting towards LA 2028 and the 2036 Olympics, which India hopes to host, the panellists discussed points of improvement that could propel the country up the medal tally.

"We need to instil the culture of sports in our children. However big the infrastructure we create, if we are not able to connect that with the people then it won't be of use," said Putul Kumari, Senior Vice President, National Rifle Association of India. She elucidated the example of Haryana as a state that has managed to preserve the sports culture in legacy sports like wrestling, kabaddi and kho kho.



From left: Commodore P. K. Garg (Former CEO, Target Olympic Podium Scheme), Adille Sumariwalla (Vice President, World Athletics), Shiva Keshavan (Head, Scholarship & Olympic Sports Strategy, Reliance Foundation), and Putul Kumari (Sr. Vice President, National Rifle Association of India) during the Conclave. R. V. MOORTHY